PSCI 3328 - International Relations

Lecture 10 - Who Matters? Identity, Gender, Race, and Class in World Politics

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PSCI 3328 - Attendance

Introduction

- Proposal grades + feedback out
- Last week: Levels of Analysis (individual, group, state, system)
- Today we go deeper into the **group and individual** levels, and ask: whose experiences and identities shape world politics?
- This connects directly to constructivism (and beyond it!) and the idea that **ideas, norms, and identities matter**

Today's Schedule

- Constructivism and Identity
- Women and Masculinity in IR
- Race and Class in World Politics

Constructivism and Identity

The Readings

What stood out to you from this week's readings? What surprised you, challenged you, or confused you?

Quick Recall: Levels of Analysis

- Last week we established that **where you look** determines **what you find**
- Individual, group, state, system: each level offers different explanations
- Today: we zoom into the **individual and group level**, but with system-wide implications
- The question shifts from *where to look* to **who are we looking at, and who are we ignoring?**

Constructivism: A Deeper Look?

- We touched on constructivism when discussing norms and institutions (Finnemore)
- **Core claim**: the international system is not just material (guns, money, geography) but also **social** (ideas, norms, identities)
- Hopf: constructivism challenges neorealism by arguing that anarchy does not have a fixed meaning

“Anarchy Is What States Make of It”

- Neorealism: anarchy forces all states to behave the same way (self-help, power maximization)
- Constructivism: the **meaning** of anarchy depends on the identities and shared understandings of the actors
- The same structural condition (no world government) can produce very different behaviors depending on **who the actors think they are** and **who they think others are**
    - Not just about Constructivism, but it is the “-ism” that more deeply tackles the question of identity as a standalone issue

What Is Identity?

When we say “identity” in IR, what do you think that means? Can you give examples?

Identity in IR

- **Identity**: how actors understand themselves and are understood by others
- Identities tell you **who you are**, **who others are**, and **what your interests should be**
  - Example: the identity "great power" implies certain behaviors, interests, and expectations that "small state" does not
- Identities are not fixed: they are **socially constructed** through practice and interaction

Identity Shapes Interests

- A state that sees itself as a “leader of the free world” has different interests than one that sees itself as a “non-aligned nation”
- These identities are not just labels; they **produce** specific policies and behaviors

The Power of Social Practice

- Hopf: power is not just military or economic; it is also **discursive** (the power of ideas, language, norms)
- Social practices **reproduce** identities and structures
  - Example: every time the US intervened militarily during the Cold War, it reinforced its identity as a great power *and* the international structure that gave that identity meaning
- Can you think of a current example where a state's actions reinforce its identity?

Why Does This Matter?

- If identities are constructed rather than given, then they can **change**
- And if identities shape interests, then **changing who matters** in world politics can change outcomes
- This opens the door to a critical question: **whose identities have been centered in IR, and whose have been ignored?**
- Why do we care about this in the context of Geopolitics?

Women and Masculinity in IR

Who Is the Default Actor in IR?

- Think about what we have studied so far: leaders, states, armies, diplomats
- Traditional IR centers on a particular kind of actor: the **rational statesman**, the **soldier**, the **diplomat**
- The assumptions baked into IR theory reflect a particular experience of the world, not necessarily a universal one

Who Is the Default Actor in IR?

BREAKING: Kim Jong Un is set to formally name his daughter, Kim Ju Ae, as North Korea's next leader.

Róisín Michaux
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If true this would be a huge win for feminism. Women are grossly underrepresented in the dictatorship and authoritarianism fields.

Enloe's Question: "Where Are the Women?"

- Cynthia Enloe asks us to look for women in international politics, not because it is "nice," but because it **reveals hidden structures of power**
  - Impacts of masculinity are often not interrogated
  - The ways women impact international politics are ignored or downplayed

Enloe's Question

- Military bases depend on local women's labor; diplomatic culture relies on the unpaid work of diplomatic spouses; global supply chains run on women's labor
- The question is not just "where are the women?" but **"what does it mean that we haven't been asking?"**

Masculinity in IR

- Cohn's insight: the language of national security is shaped by assumptions about masculinity and rationality
- Defense intellectuals use abstract, technocratic language that distances decision-makers from human consequences
- "Rational" and "tough" are valued; "emotional" and "soft" are dismissed
- This matters because **language shapes what counts as legitimate knowledge and policy**

Women as Actors, Not Just Subjects

- Women are not just victims of conflict; they are **actors**: combatants, peacebuilders, negotiators, community leaders
  - E.g., over 25% of Ukraine's army
- UN Security Council Resolution 1325 (2000): recognized women's roles in peace and security at the international level
- Yet women remain underrepresented in peace negotiations and post-conflict governance

Women as Actors, Not Just Subjects

Is this becoming more relevant in today's world?

Race and Class in World Politics

How Do We Define Race?

- An intersubjectively defined group of human beings sharing physical characteristics regarded as common among people of shared ancestry
- Not the same as ethnicity or lineage
- Most racial categories commonly used today are quite **recent** and frequently shift in significant ways (different view, even across countries with “similar” culture)

About Race and social constructs

How is this relevant in IR?

Race as an Identity in IR

- If constructivism tells us that identities are socially constructed, then **race** is one of the most powerful identity categories shaping world politics
- Yet mainstream IR has largely treated race as irrelevant
- Zvobgo and Loken ask: **why has the discipline ignored one of the most consequential social constructs in modern history?**

The Discipline's Blind Spot

- Zvobgo and Loken: the field of IR was born in the early 20th century, a period of explicit hierarchy, colonialism, and empire
- Early IR scholars operated within assumptions about which peoples were capable of self-governance
- As the discipline professionalized, this racial foundation was **erased**, not resolved

How Race Shapes World Politics

- The core story of international politics is “raced” (Zvobgo and Loken)
  - **Who counts as a legitimate actor?** Colonial and post-colonial hierarchies determined which states were taken seriously
  - **Whose knowledge matters?** Western IR theory is treated as universal (remember the system discours?)
- Race shapes perceptions of **risk, threat, and which issues are worthy of concern**

Discussion

Can you think of examples where racial perceptions might shape how the international community responds to a crisis? Think about differences in media coverage, humanitarian aid, refugee policy...

What Is an Economic Class Approach to IR?

- **Economics as the driving force**: the “substructure” behind everything else in human society (the “superstructure”)
- Economic classes are groups defined by their relationship to the economic system (the “means of production”)
- International relations is another arena in which **class conflict** takes place

The Intersection of Race and Class

- Du Bois (1915): WWI was fundamentally about **colonial competition for Africa**
- The exploitation of non-white peoples was not a side effect of imperialism; it was the **engine** driving great power rivalry
- Du Bois: *"The present world war is, then, the result of jealousies engendered by the recent rise of armed national associations of labor and capital whose aim is the exploitation of the wealth of the world mainly outside the European circle of nations"*

Du Bois: Race and Class Together

- The “color line” paid dividends: white workers were asked to share the spoils of exploiting colonized peoples
- This is a **race and class** argument simultaneously: racial hierarchy enabled economic exploitation, and economic exploitation reinforced racial hierarchy
- Does this framing change how you understand the causes of great conflicts compared to what you may have learned before?

Why Bring Race and Class Back In?

- Not about “adding a variable” but about **rethinking foundational concepts**
- Power, sovereignty, anarchy, legitimacy: all developed in a world structured by racial and economic hierarchy
- Understanding this does not invalidate these concepts; it **enriches** our ability to use them critically

Discussion

Think about the concepts we have covered in this course so far: anarchy, power, levels of analysis. How might any of these look different if we account for these identity-based concepts?

Wrapping Up

Connecting the Dots

- **Constructivism** tells us identities are socially constructed and shape interests
- **Attention to women's roles and masculinity** shows us whose experiences have been centered and whose have been invisible
- **Race and class analysis** shows us how the discipline itself was shaped by the power structures it claims to study
- Together, these lenses do not replace traditional IR; they **strengthen** it

Summary

- **Identity** is not a given; it is constructed through social practices and has real consequences for world politics
- Asking **"who matters?"** is an analytical question that improves our theories
- These perspectives operate at the **group and individual** levels, but they have **systemic implications**

Questions?